The Weight of Glory



Accessible Adventure of the Week

Make Lives Better through D&D

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Wyrmworkspublishing.com is the first place to get notified when our compendium of comprehensive game mechanics for including characters with disabilities, mental illness, and neurodivergence in fifth edition goes live on Kickstarter.

Content Trigger Warnings

This adventure includes death and violence, undead, disapproval by parents, and death of parents.

I'm so sorry. I was just trying to help!

Dad was a hero but died without the glory he desired and deserved. Can you help bring reconciliation to his grieving child?

This one-shot sidequest adventure is designed for 4-5 characters, level 5-7, with a total of 20-22 levels.

Background & Synopsis

Maledos, a tiefling sorcerer, is looking for help. Their father died in the battle, and they wish to give him a proper burial, but the battlefield is haunted by sword wraiths who prevent the battlefield from being disturbed. What the players don't know is that Maledos was the one who ended the battle with a fireball that also killed their father, who is one of the sword wraiths.

The adventure begins when the party is traveling along a road through the woods and encounters a cottage with a dying couple. As the party comes to their aid, they learn that the couple had traveled to a nearby town to visit their daughter as she gave birth to a new granddaughter. Because it took longer than expected, they were away and missed the monthly "Valor Day" ritual that would appease the sword wraiths of the nearby battleground. When they returned home, the sword wraiths attacked them. They begged for mercy, explaining about their granddaughter, the sword wraiths decided that the granddaughter doesn't deserve more glory than they, so she must die, so they intend to go to the town the next night. The couple begs the party to go to the battlefield and stop the sword wraiths before they kill their family.

As the party heads to the battlefield, they encounter Maledos, who had come to help the couple with their observance but left when they weren't there. They witnessed the attack but knew they didn't have the power to protect the couple and hid. They want to put the undead to rest, especially their father.

The party sets out for the battlefield and arrives to discover the sword wraiths about to head out for the town. During the battle, the party notices that the crests represent both sides of the battle. The Sword Wraith Commander is Maledos's father, and he (correctly) blames Maledos for his death and, more importantly to him, his loss of glory.

If the party destroys the sword wraiths, they will come back the next night, as they are subconsciously being raised by Maledos's guilt. This will repeat until the party helps Maledos and his father reconcile with the promise of building a monument there, after which the sword wraiths instantly crumble.

Adventure Hooks

The party will begin this side adventure when they encounter the broken house. If they ignore it and pass by, the couple within will call out, "Is someone out there? Help!"

Where are we?

This adventure takes place near a forest between two large towns, one of which is about a day's walk away. It could take place in nearly any fantasy world, and while it's designed for a forest setting, it could take place nearly anywhere. It could also fit well into many Ravenloft settings as a side adventure or even to treat Maledos as a dark lord.

The Glory Has Departed

As the players travel along the road through the woods on the way to the next town, they pass a cob cottage with smashed walls and a torn thatch roof. All the windows are broken in. Any investigation indicates that the destruction is recent. While the party is investigating the cottage or as they pass by, they hear a weak cry: "Is someone there? Please help us! We're trapped!" Under the rubble, the party finds a middle-aged couple, Torsten & Anika, trapped and barely alive, covered in bruises and slash cuts. The party can use whatever means they have to stabilize the couple.

Once stabilized, the couple will tell the party what happened:

> We should've known better. We should've just waited until after, but we wanted to be there for our daughter, and we didn't know it would take so long!
> Our Lorena was going to have a baby soon, and we knew Valor Day was coming, but we thought there would be enough time. But then the baby didn't come, and she didn't come, and once she finally came, it was too late. There was no way we could be back in time. But we thought, "Maybe if we're not there, it won't matter. They won't need to be honored, because there will be nobody there to forget them."
>
> We were wrong. When we got back, they soon found us. We tried to explain to them why we were gone, but it didn't matter. They decided that Lorena and the baby would need to be sacrificed so we wouldn't forget them anymore. They attacked us, destroyed our home, and left us for dead, and we would've been if you hadn't stopped to help.

When asked for clarification, they will tell the party about the soldiers who died on a nearby battlefield, but because some wizard (They don't know who.) ended the battle abruptly with an explosive spell, the warriors died in disgrace. Every year on the anniversary of the battle or anytime their remains are disturbed, they arise to get glory for themselves, so we hold a celebration called "Valor Day" to remember them and their mighty deeds.

This year, they were away on Valor Day, visiting their daughter, Lorena, who was having a baby, but she gave birth later than expected, so they were delayed. (They will get sidetracked talking about how beautiful their new granddaughter, Yasmina, is.) But now, the soldiers are angry and planning to exact their revenge on Lorena and Yasmina. They plead with the party to stop the soldiers and save their daughter and granddaughter and give directions to the battlefield, which is about a mile from their home.

If asked why they don't just move away from the battlefield, they will say that someone must remain to honor them, or they'll lay waste to the nearby towns.

Dramatis Personae

Maledos

Medium humanoid (tiefling sorcerer), neutral good

Armor Class 12 (15 with mage armor)
Hit Points 32
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
8 (-1)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	13 (+1)	10 (+0)	18 (+4)

Saving Throws Con +4, Cha +6
Skills Arcana +3, Deception +6, History +3, Intimidation +6
Damage Resistances fire
Senses darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 10
Languages Celestial, Common, Infernal, Sylvan
Challenge 0 (10 XP)

Cramps (Severity Degree 3, Periodic). You experience sudden painful tightening of muscles in your body with little or no warning. This tightness makes the cramped part of your body completely unusable and distracting. This cramp may always be in the same body part or travel around the body, typically in the same region. The cramp lasts (Severity Degree)d4 minutes. At the end of the duration, you must succeed on a DC 8 + (Severity Degree) Strength saving throw or the cramp moves to a different part of the same region of the body, such as lower abdomen to upper abdomen or from calf to shin or from left leg to right leg for another (Severity Degree)d4 minutes, after which you must succeed on a DC + (Severity Degree) Strength saving throw or continue the process, the DC decreasing by 1 each time. Any action that requires concentration (e.g. maintaining a spell) requires a successful DC 10 + (Severity Degree) Constitution saving throw per round to maintain concentration.

It will recur in 1d20 days.

Spellcasting. Maledos is a 5th-level spellcaster. Their spellcasting ability is Charisma (spell save DC 14, +6 to hit with spell attacks). Maledos has the following sorcerer spells prepared:

Cantrips (at will): *chill touch, fire bolt, lightning lure, mage hand, mending, thaumaturgy*
1st level (4 slots): *expeditious retreat, mage armor, magic missile*
2nd level (3 slots): *cloud of daggers, darkness, misty step*
3rd level (2 slots): *fireball*

Sorcery Points. Maledos has 5 sorcery points that you regain when you finish a long rest.

Metamagic - Distant Spell. When Maledos casts a spell that has a range of 5 ft. or greater, Maledos can spend 1 sorcery point to double the range of the spell (or make the range 30 ft. for a spell with a range of touch).

Metamagic - Empowered Spell. When Maledos rolls damage for a spell, Maledos can spend 1 sorcery point to reroll up to 4 of the dice. Maledos must use the new rolls and Maledos can use this option even if Maledos has already used another Metamagic option.

Strength of the Grave. When damage (that isn't radiant or from a critical hit) reduces Maledos to 0 HP, Maledos can make a CHA saving throw (DC 5 + the damage taken). On a success, Maledos instead drops to 1 HP (and can't use this feature again until finishing a long rest).

Infernal Legacy. Maledos knows the *thaumaturgy* cantrip. They can cast the *hellish rebuke* spell as a 2nd-level spell once with this trait and regain the ability to do so when they finish a long rest. They can cast the *darkness* spell once with this trait and regain the ability to do so when they finish a long rest. Charisma is their spellcasting ability for these spells.

Actions

Hand Crossbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, range 30/120 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing damage.

Dagger. *Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d4 + 2) piercing damage.

Sword Wraith Commander

Medium undead, lawful evil

Armor Class 18 (breastplate, shield)
Hit Points 127 (15d8 + 60)
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	14 (+2)	18 (+4)	11 (+0)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)

Skills Perception +4
Damage Resistances necrotic; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks
Damage Immunities poison
Condition Immunities exhaustion, frightened, poisoned, unconscious
Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 14
Languages the languages it knew in life
Challenge 8 (3,900 XP)
Proficiency Bonus +3

Martial Fury. As a bonus action, the sword wraith can make one weapon attack, which deals an extra 9 (2d8) necrotic damage on a hit. If it does so, attack rolls against it have advantage until the start of its next turn.

Turning Defiance. The sword wraith and any other sword wraiths within 30 feet of it have advantage on saving throws against effects that turn undead.

Actions

Multiattack. The sword wraith makes two weapon attacks.

Longsword. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 8 (1d8 + 4) slashing damage, or 9 (1d10 + 4) slashing damage if used with two hands.

Longbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, range 150/600 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) piercing damage.

Call to Honor (1/Day). To use this action, the sword wraith must have taken damage during the current combat. If the sword wraith can use this action, it gives itself advantage on attack rolls until the end of its next turn, and 1d4 + 1 **sword wraith warriors** appear in unoccupied spaces within 30 feet of it. The warriors last until they drop to 0 hit points, and they take their turns immediately after the commander's turn on the same initiative count.

Sword Wraith Warrior

Medium undead, lawful evil

Armor Class 16 (chain shirt, shield)
Hit Points 45 (6d8 + 18)
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	12 (+1)	17 (+3)	6 (-2)	9 (-1)	10 (+0)

Damage Resistances necrotic; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks
Damage Immunities poison
Condition Immunities exhaustion, frightened, poisoned, unconscious
Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 9
Languages the languages it knew in life
Challenge 3 (700 XP)
Proficiency Bonus +2

Martial Fury. As a bonus action, the sword wraith can make one weapon attack. If it does so, attack rolls against it have advantage until the start of its next turn.

Actions

Longsword. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 8 (1d8 + 4) slashing damage, or 9 (1d10 + 4) slashing damage if used with two hands.

Longbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, range 150/600 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d8 + 1) piercing damage.



The Sauce Spooned over Failure

As the party heads toward the battlefield through the woods, they come upon an old abandoned shack. Anyone with a passive Wisdom (Perception) of 10 or greater will hear the sound of crying coming from the shack, and the words, "Too late," and, "I'm so sorry," through the crying.



Regardless of whether the party attempts stealth or not (Attempts will have advantage due to the crying.), they will find a tiefling sitting on a broken crate in the shed who, when noticing the party, will jump up defensively, ready to attack.

> The crying stops suddenly as the tiefling jumps to their feet and grabs a staff which starts glowing. "What do you want?!" they yell, "Why are you desecrating this sacred land? Get out while you can!"

Once the party calms the situation and gains Maledos's trust that they only want to help, Maledos will tell the party that they were planning to help the couple with Valor Day, but when they were clearly not home, they left. They witnessed the attack but hid, because they knew they were no match for the soldiers and would be killed. They ask whether the party would be willing to help destroy the soldiers once and for all.

Failure is an Orphan

The party sets out for the battlefield and arrives to discover the sword wraiths about to head out for the town. During the battle, the party notices that the crests represent both sides of the battle. The Sword Wraith Commander is Maledos's father, and he (correctly) blames Maledos for his death and, more importantly to him, his loss of glory.

If the party destroys the sword wraiths, they will come back the next night, as they are subconsciously being raised by Maledos's guilt. This will repeat until the party helps Maledos and his father reconcile with the promise of building a monument there, after which the sword wraiths instantly crumble.

When the party arrives with Maledos at the battlefield, they witness the undead soldiers, a **sword wraith commander** and 5 **sword wraith warriors**, rising from the ground, a sword wraith commander and 5 sword wraith warriors, leaving toward the town to exact their revenge. The commander suddenly stops and raises a hand, which halts the rest of the soldiers. The commander turns and faces Maedos and points a finger at them saying in a low raspy voice like a growl, "The source of our ignominy. Comrades, our vengeance has been usurped by a greater requirement." They turn to the party and move to attack.

During the fight, Maledos and the commander are screaming at each other over the din of battle. Maledos keeps apologizing, and the commander speaks of Maledos stealing the glory. Maledos will refer to the commander as "father," and the commander will respond with, "You are not my child. My child is dead to me. My child died when my glory died." They will hear hints in the argument that Maledos ended the battle with a fireball that wiped out both armies. The party might also notice that the sword wraiths wear the tattered colors and emblems of two different armies, as Maledos wiped out both, but now both have united for vengeance and glory.

If the party defeats the sword wraiths, Maledos suggests that they go back to Torsten and Anika's to check on them, help them, and get some rest. The next day, the sword wraiths will attack them at the cottage before they leave.

Monumental Undertaking

No matter how many times they're defeated, the sword wraiths will keep returning every day no matter how much damage they receive unless the party finds a way to permanently banish them. Unknown to anyone, Maledos is subconsciously raising them as their guilt combines with their sorcery. This will continue until Maledos makes restitution by building a monument on the battlefield in their honor. Once Maledos promises to build the monument, the sword wraiths crumble to dust but will reform the next day if the promise is not kept.

The Dungeon Master may want to invite the players to help Maledos design and build the monument from the ample stone in the area.

Cottage Cheese

Once the monument is built, Torsten and Anika decide to leave instead of rebuilding their destroyed home. They gather what belongings they can salvage and carry, and if the party is heading toward the same town, they'll ask to journey with the party. If not, Maledos will escort them.

Credits & Copyright

- Lead writer, editor & developer: Dale Critchley
- Artwork public domain illustrations by Jim Cooper, Yuri_B, Artie_Navarre

Author Bio

Dale Critchley is the owner, lead writer, and chief tea drinker at Wyrmworks Publishing. He's been playing tabletop role-playing games since 1982 and launched Wyrmworks Publishing as a hobby in 2001 to share his homebrew resources with the world. In 2021, after seeing the power that a TTRPG group can have to change the lives of the participants for the better, he rededicated Wyrmworks Publishing to focus on using TTRPGs to intentionally improve the lives of others and turned a hobby into a full time pursuit.

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